castes got stiffer penalties for the same crime. Interestingly, the Brahmins were punished more for flouting the caste order. Alberuni writes, ‘If a Brahman eats in the house of a Shudra for sundry days, he is expelled from his caste and can never regain it.’

Alberuni reports that ‘the Hindus, are not very severe in punishing whoredom’. Some of these ‘whores’ even ‘sing, dance, and play’ in their temples (this must be in reference to devadasis). Alberuni calls this a fault of the kings, who make prostitutes ‘an attraction for their cities, a bait of pleasure for their subjects, for no other but financial reasons’. The kings use the revenues from the business of prostitution, ‘both as fines and taxes’, to offset their military expenses.

‘As regards charms and incantations,’ writes Alberuni, ‘the Hindus have a firm belief in them, and they, as a rule, are much inclined towards them.’ Hindu men also fast in various ways and for different objectives, such as to vanquish enemies, to gain wealth, wisdom or health or to be a favourite of the women. On one particular fasting day of the year, ‘they soil themselves with the dung of cows, and break fasting by feeding upon a mixture of cow’s milk, urine, and dung’. Giving alms is considered meritorious, and many donate up to 10 per cent of their income.

‘The Hindus marry at a very young age; therefore, the parents arrange the marriage’ of their children, writes Alberuni. No gifts are exchanged, but the husband gives a gift to his new wife, which becomes her personal wealth on which he has no claim. ‘Husband and wife can only be separated by death, as they have no divorce.’ During a woman’s menstrual cycle, ‘the husband is not allowed to cohabit with his wife, nor even to come near her in the house, because during this time she is impure’. ‘A man may marry one to four wives,’ writes Alberuni. The number allowed ‘depends upon the caste’. A Brahmin ‘may take four, a Kshatriya three, a Vaisya two wives, and a Shudra one. Every man of a caste may marry a woman of his own caste or one of the castes or caste below his; but nobody is allowed to marry a woman of a caste superior to his own’. For a man, ‘if one of his wives die, he may take another one to complete the legitimate number’. If the husband dies, however,

> [the wife] cannot marry another man. She has only to choose between two things—either to remain a widow as long as she lives or to burn herself; and the latter eventuality is considered the preferable, because as a widow she is ill-treated as long as she lives. As